

Roasted yellow pepper sauce

While this recipe calls for a fairly hot pepper, you can step it up even higher by using a fresh habañero pepper—the boldest of the bold. The combined sweetness of the bell pepper, banana, and caramelized onion will tone down the heat and bring out the citrus overtones of the habañero. I do suggest, however, that unless you are a real chile head, use just a small piece of the habañero to start with; add more only after you have tasted the sauce. The habañero generally has thin skin, which is why I roast only the bell peppers.

2 yellow bell peppers

1 medium onion, coarsely chopped

2 tablespoons olive oil

½ to 1 fresh hot pepper (jalapeño, Serrano, or habañero), minced

½ banana

¼ to ½ cup dry white wine or vegetable broth [60 to 125ml]

Salt and freshly ground pepper

1 or 2 splashes of peach, mango, white wine, or cider vinegar

1. Preheat the broiler. **Cut** the bell peppers lengthwise in half; remove the stems, seeds, and excess ribs. Slit the ends slightly so you can flatten them out. Place the peppers stem side up under the broiler with the rack set about 4 inches [8 to 10cm] from the heat and broil until they are blackened, about 10 minutes. Let cool, then scrape off the blackened skin and cut the peppers into strips.
2. In a small skillet or saucepan, **cook** the onion in 1 tablespoon of the olive oil over medium heat until soft and lightly browned, 5 to 7 minutes.
3. In a food processor, **combine** the roasted bell peppers, cooked onion, hot pepper, banana, and remaining oil. Blend briefly. With the machine on, gradually add the wine, mixing until smooth and creamy.

4. Strain the sauce through a food mill or fine mesh strainer and scrape into a medium saucepan. Bring to a simmer and cook until reduced slightly. The sauce should be a bit thick, but not heavy. Season with salt, pepper, and vinegar to taste.

MAKES ABOUT 1 CUP [250ML]

